

SUNDAY SERVICE

SERMON OUTLINE

& DEVOTIONAL NOTES

*"Forget the former things; do not dwell on the past.
See, I am doing a new thing! Now it springs up; do you not perceive it?
I am making a way in the wilderness and streams in the wasteland."*

— Isaiah 43:18–19 (NIV)

SERMON TITLE:

"BEHOLD, I AM DOING A NEW THING"

A Message of Hope, Release, and Divine Renewal

PART ONE: SERMON OUTLINE

Text: Isaiah 43:18–19 (NIV) | **Supporting:** Philippians 3:13–14; Revelation 21:5; Lamentations 3:22–23

INTRODUCTION

Open with a question: Have you ever been so trapped by what used to be that you failed to see what God is already doing right now? Many of us carry the **weight of former seasons — past failures, losses, disappointments, or even former victories — that blind us to the fresh movement of the Holy Spirit in the present.** Isaiah 43:18–19 is God's direct pastoral counsel: stop staring backward and start perceiving what He is doing now.

Context note: God had just recounted the Exodus miracle (vv. 16–17), Israel's greatest historical memory. Yet He says — 'Do not dwell on that.' Why? Because what He is about to do is even greater. This frames the entire sermon: God is not nostalgic. He is always moving forward.

MAIN POINTS

I. THE COMMAND: STOP DWELLING ON THE PAST (v. 18)

"Forget the former things; do not dwell on the past."

- A. Two imperatives: 'forget' (*shamar*) and 'do not dwell' — active, deliberate choices, not passive forgetting.
- B. This is not a denial of history. God Himself just recounted the past (vv. 16–17). The issue is unhealthy fixation — when the past becomes a prison.
- C. Application: What former things are you holding onto? Past wounds? Past glory? Both can become spiritual anchors that keep you from moving forward.

II. THE ANNOUNCEMENT: GOD IS DOING SOMETHING NEW (v. 19a)

"See, I am doing a new thing! Now it springs up; do you not perceive it?"

- D. "I am doing" — present progressive. This new thing is not future; it is already in motion.
- E. "Now it springs up" — the Hebrew *tsamach* (to sprout, germinate). Like a seed already breaking ground beneath the soil — God's new thing may be invisible but it is alive.
- F. "Do you not perceive it?" — a rhetorical challenge. God is asking His people to sharpen their spiritual perception. Cf. **Elisha's servant in 2 Kings 6:17** — eyes must be opened to see what is already there.
- G. Application: The new thing may already be happening — in your family, church, ministry, personal life. Don't miss it because you are still looking the wrong direction.

III. THE PROVISION: GOD MAKES A WAY WHERE THERE IS NO WAY (v. 19b)

"I am making a way in the wilderness and streams in the wasteland."

- H. "Wilderness" and "wasteland" are deliberate — God's new thing does not come in easy places. It comes precisely where things seem most impossible.
- I. A "way" speaks of direction and guidance. "Streams" speak of refreshing, sustenance, and life in dry places. Both are needed for a journey.
- J. **Cross-reference:** John 14:6 — Jesus is the Way. Revelation 21:5 — "I am making everything new." Romans 8:28 — all things work together for good.
- K. Application: You may be in the wilderness. Your situation may feel like a wasteland. But God is not lost — He is working. He is building a road and a river in the very place that looks most hopeless.

IV. THE INVITATION: PERCEIVE WITH EYES OF FAITH

- L. Faith is not hoping for something that has not started — it is perceiving something God has already begun. (cf. Hebrews 11:1)
- M. Philippians 3:13–14 — Paul's personal application: forgetting what is behind, pressing toward what is ahead. Paul had a glorious past (Pharisee, blameless) and a painful past (persecutor). He chose to let go of both.
- N. Call to action: Ask God to open your eyes to what He is already doing. Come before Him in surrender, releasing the grip of former things.

CONCLUSION

The God of Isaiah 43 is not a God who is stuck in the past. He is the God of the present tense — 'I AM doing a new thing.' He invites you today to unclasp your hands from former seasons, lift your eyes, and perceive the fresh wind of His Spirit already moving. The road is being built. The river is starting to flow. Will you walk forward with Him?

Closing charge: As you walk out today, leave something behind — a worry, a regret, a past glory — and receive the new thing God is doing in this season of your life.

Suggested Altar Call: Invite those who feel stuck in the past — whether in grief, regret, past success, or bitterness — to come forward for prayer and release.

PART TWO: DEVOTIONAL NOTES

For personal use, small group reflection, or mid-week study

DAY 1 — RELEASING THE FORMER THINGS

Key Verse: *"Forget the former things; do not dwell on the past." (Isaiah 43:18)*

Reflection:

Notice that God does not say 'the former things were worthless.' He had just celebrated the Exodus miracle in the previous verses. The issue is not whether the past was good or bad — both can become chains. When we idolize former victories, we become passive, waiting for God to repeat the past. When we rehearse former wounds, we become bitter, unable to receive the new. God's command is a radical act of spiritual hygiene: clean the lenses of your heart so you can see clearly.

Personal Reflection Questions:

- ❖ What 'former things' do you find yourself dwelling on most — past successes or past hurts?
- ❖ How has clinging to the past affected your prayer life, your hope, or your willingness to step out in faith?
- ❖ Is there a specific memory, experience, or season you need to symbolically place in God's hands today?

Prayer:

Lord, I acknowledge that I have held on to [name it honestly before God]. Today I make a deliberate choice to release it into Your hands. Teach me to remember rightly — not to be enslaved by memory, but freed by it into trust in You. Open my eyes to the new thing You are doing. Amen.

DAY 2 — SHARPENING YOUR SPIRITUAL PERCEPTION

Key Verse: *"See, I am doing a new thing! Now it springs up; do you not perceive it?" (Isaiah 43:19a)*

Reflection:

The question 'do you not perceive it?' is both tender and searching. God is not angry — He is inviting. The new thing is already happening; the question is whether we have the spiritual sensitivity to notice it. Like seeds sprouting under dark soil, God's work often begins invisibly. Gratitude journals, sabbath rest, and meditative reading of Scripture all sharpen our perception. What has God already been doing in your life that you may have dismissed as coincidence or overlooked in the busyness of life?

Personal Reflection Questions:

- ❖ Where in your life right now can you see the earliest signs of something new beginning to 'spring up'?
- ❖ What spiritual disciplines help you 'perceive' God's movements — journaling, prayer walks, solitude, Scripture meditation?
- ❖ Have you ever recognized God's new thing only in hindsight? What did that teach you about trusting Him in the present?

Prayer:

Father, give me eyes to see what You are already doing. Silence the noise of my past and the anxiety of my future so I can be fully present to Your present work. I do not want to miss what You are doing because I am looking the wrong direction. Increase my faith and my perception. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 3 — WHEN YOUR WILDERNESS BECOMES A HIGHWAY

Key Verse: *"I am making a way in the wilderness and streams in the wasteland."*
(Isaiah 43:19b)

Reflection:

A wilderness is a place of disorientation — no marked path, no reliable water source, no sense of progress. Yet this is precisely where God chooses to demonstrate His provision most dramatically. The Exodus generation walked through a literal wilderness and were sustained by manna and water from a rock. The wilderness is not a sign of God's absence. It is often the theatre of His most extraordinary work. If you are in a dry place today, you are in the right place for a miracle.

Personal Reflection Questions:

- ❖ What 'wilderness' are you currently walking through — a relationship, a career, a health journey, a spiritual dry season?
- ❖ In what ways have you experienced God's provision in difficult seasons that you might not have noticed in comfortable ones?
- ❖ What would it mean in practical terms to 'walk forward' even before you can see the full road God is building?

Prayer:

God of the wilderness, I choose to trust that where I stand right now is not outside Your care — it is inside Your plan. You make roads where none exist and rivers where only dust was before. I step forward today in faith, not because I see the full path, but because I know the One who is building it. Lead me, Lord. Amen.

SMALL GROUP / COMMUNITY DISCUSSION GUIDE

Opening (5 min): Share a time when looking back prevented you from moving forward — in any area of life.

Word (15 min): Read Isaiah 43:16–19 aloud. What strikes you most? What questions does it raise?

Discussion (20 min):

- ❖ Why do you think God commands us to forget even the good things of the past? What is the spiritual danger of living off former victories?
- ❖ What does it practically look like to 'perceive' what God is doing? How do we distinguish God's new thing from our own wishful thinking?
- ❖ How does this passage speak to people in your community who are going through a wilderness season right now?

Application (10 min): Each person shares: One 'former thing' to release, and one 'new thing' they believe God may be doing.

Close in prayer: Pray together for spiritual perception and courage to walk forward.